

JORVIK & Viking York - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Vikings Are Coming — And Staying

On the first of November, 866, York's people were celebrating All Saints' Day when a Viking army — the Great Heathen Army, which is what people actually called it — swept into the city and took it. But here's the twist most people don't know: the Vikings didn't just raid and leave. They liked York. They stayed, settled down, and turned it into Jorvik, one of the richest trading cities in Europe. For nearly a century, York was ruled by Viking kings with fantastic names — the last one was Eric Bloodaxe, who sounds terrifying and was. Viking Jorvik was crowded, busy and international: archaeologists have found silk from Central Asia, coins from Samarkand, amber from the Baltic, and a cowrie shell from the Red Sea — all in the mud of York. Down at the JORVIK Centre, you'll ride a slow "time car" through a rebuilt Viking street from exactly one thousand years ago, with houses, workshops, voices speaking Old Norse — and smells. Yes, real, engineered smells: woodsmoke, fish, leather, and the unmistakable whiff of the Viking toilet pit. The faces of some figures were even reconstructed from real Viking skulls found right here. And remember: this isn't a made-up street. It's built exactly where the real one stood, based on what came out of the ground beneath your feet.

The Great Horned Helmet Lie

Here is one of the biggest fibs in all of history, and today you get to bust it. Vikings did not wear horns on their helmets. Not one. Never. If you look around the JORVIK galleries, and later at a helmet called the Coppergate Helmet in the Yorkshire Museum across town, you will not find a single horn, because horns on a battle helmet would be a terrible idea. Imagine swinging a heavy axe at someone whose helmet has two handy handles sticking out, perfect for grabbing, twisting, and knocking his head sideways. No warrior would do that on purpose.

Real Viking helmets were simple, strong iron caps, round like a bowl, sometimes with a bar to guard the nose and eyes. In fact, in all the digging that has ever been done, archaeologists have found only one helmet complete enough to rebuild from the whole Viking age, pieced back together from rusty fragments found on a farm in Norway. One. And it has no horns.

So where did the horns come from? From the theatre. Almost nine hundred years after the Vikings, in the eighteen seventies, a German artist named Carl Emil Doepler designed the costumes for a giant, booming set of operas by the composer Richard Wagner, full of gods and heroes and doom. He gave some of the characters helmets with horns and wings to make them look wild and ancient and dramatic on stage. The audiences loved it. Painters copied it, then storybooks copied the paintings, then cartoons copied the storybooks, and before long every picture of a Viking, everywhere, had horns. A costume designer basically invented the look of the Viking in an afternoon, and the whole world believed him.

Here is the funny part. There are a few really old horned helmets from Scandinavia, but they come from more than a thousand years before the Vikings, back in the Bronze Age, and they were not for fighting at all. They were special objects for ceremonies, probably worn by priests, and only a couple of people ever wore them. The Vikings never saw them either.

So next time you spot a cartoon Viking with big curly horns, you can say, with total confidence, nope. The real Vikings who walked the streets right here under your feet wore plain iron caps, or often no helmet at all, just a wool hat and a stubborn attitude. The horns are pretend. You know the truth now.

A Day on a Viking Street

Close your eyes for a second and put yourself on the real Coppergate, one thousand years ago. You wake up in a house made of woven wooden sticks packed with mud and moss, with a roof of straw or wooden shingles, and a fire smoking in the middle of the floor. There is no chimney, so the smoke just drifts up and out through the roof, and everything, including you, smells of woodsmoke all the time. It is dark inside, and a bit crowded, because your whole family sleeps on benches along the walls, maybe with a dog and some chickens for company.

Step outside and the street is buzzing. Coppergate is narrow and muddy, lined with fences and workshops, and the neighbours are noisy. Next door someone is hammering hot metal. Across the way a woman is carving combs out of deer antler, and further along a man is spinning wooden cups on a foot-powered machine, which is exactly how the street got its name. You can hear geese honking, pigs snuffling, people haggling, and a language called Old Norse, the great-great-grandparent of modern Icelandic, being shouted and laughed all around you.

Down by the river Ouse, boats are unloading. Some carry fish and firewood from nearby, but others have come a very long way, and this is the amazing part. Traders in Jorvik got their hands on silk from thousands of miles east, golden amber from the cold Baltic Sea, and once even a little cowrie shell that lives only in warm seas near Arabia. A Viking child in muddy York might hold a shell that had travelled further than anyone they would ever meet.

What did you do all day? If you were a Viking kid, you worked. You fetched water, gathered firewood, fed the animals, helped spin wool, and learned a trade from your parents. But there was fun too. Children played with carved wooden toys and little boats, they had ice skates made from horse leg bones for the frozen river in winter, and grownups and children alike loved a board game a bit like chess, where one side defends a king and the other side tries to trap him. And everyone told stories by the fire, long tales of gods and monsters and heroes, because there were no books for most people, only voices and memory.

It was smoky, smelly, freezing in winter and packed with people and animals. But it was also busy, clever, and connected to half the world. That is the street the JORVIK ride is about to carry you through.

The Muddy Miracle Under Your Feet

Why does York know so much about the Vikings? Because of magic mud. In 1976, before a shopping center was built at Coppergate — “street of the cup-makers” in Old Norse — archaeologists got five years to dig. What they found amazed the world. The ground here is wet, oxygen-poor clay, and things that normally rot away — wood, leather, cloth, plants, even insects — had survived for a thousand years. The archaeologists found entire Viking house walls still standing waist-high, fences, workshops, forty thousand objects in all: shoes, socks, combs carved from antler, ice skates made of horse bones, board games, padlocks, pans — the complete everyday life of ordinary Viking families, not kings. They even found thousand-year-old fleas, and eggs of the stomach worms that lived inside actual Vikings, which tells scientists the Vikings had... pretty rumibly tummies. The dig became famous; thousands of people queued to watch. When it ended, York built the JORVIK Centre right on top, and in the glass-floored gallery you can look down at some of the real preserved timbers, exactly where they were found. Archaeologists say a single cubic meter of Coppergate mud holds more history than a treasure chest of gold. Though they would probably also accept the gold.

The Helmet at the Bottom of the Pit

Of all the forty thousand things dug up around here, one is so special it lives in a glass case of its own in a museum across the city. It is a helmet, and the story of finding it is pure luck and pure drama.

It was the twelfth of May, nineteen eighty-two, in the afternoon. The archaeologists had finished part of the dig, and a big mechanical digger was scooping out soil to make room for the new building. Suddenly the metal bucket clanged against something hard, deep down in what had once been a well or a pit. The digger driver stopped. Down in the mud was a lump of rusty metal, and when the archaeologists rushed over and cleaned it, their jaws dropped. It was a helmet, and not a Viking one. It was even older, made by the Anglo-Saxon people who lived in York before the Vikings arrived, more than twelve hundred years ago.

This helmet is a masterpiece. It is made of iron, with strips of shiny brass, and a curtain of tiny iron rings, called mail, to protect the neck. It has guards for the cheeks, a bar to guard the nose, and two beautiful brass eyebrows that meet in a little animal head. Best of all, running over the top is a strip of brass with words scratched into it, in Latin, a prayer that names a man called Oshere. Nobody knows exactly who Oshere was, but this was almost certainly his helmet, worn or owned by a real Anglo-Saxon warrior with a real name. That is incredibly rare. In more than a thousand years of digging all over England, only a tiny handful of helmets this old have ever been found. You could count them on one hand.

Why was such a treasure at the bottom of a pit? That is a mystery. Maybe it was hidden on purpose to keep it safe, and the owner never came back. Maybe it was thrown away, or lost, or dropped in as a gift to the gods. The mud is not telling. But because the ground here is so wet and airless, the same magic that saved the Viking shoes and combs also saved this helmet for us, so that you, today, can look a twelve-hundred-year-old warrior's own helmet right in the eyebrows.

When you have time in York, the helmet is worth hunting down in the Yorkshire Museum. It is one of the greatest things ever pulled out of the ground in this whole country, and a mechanical digger very nearly scooped it up by accident.

The Cleverest Hands in Jorvik

Jorvik was not just a place where Vikings lived. It was a place where they made things, thousands of things, and the mud saved enough of them that we know exactly what the workshops did. This whole street was basically a row of busy little factories run by families.

Start with the name. Coppergate has nothing to do with the metal copper. In Old Norse it means the street of the cup-makers, and sure enough, archaeologists found piles of wooden cores, the leftover middles from spinning bowls and cups on a lathe. A lathe is a machine that turns a lump of wood round and round while you carve it, and the Jorvik cup-makers worked theirs with their feet, shaping smooth wooden bowls all day long.

Then there were the comb-makers, and combs mattered a lot, because almost everyone had head lice and everyone wanted them out. Vikings did not carve combs from wood, which snaps. They used antler, the strong headgear a deer grows and drops every single year, sawn and riveted into beautiful combs with teeth so fine they still work today. Comb-makers were skilled travellers who moved from town to town, and Jorvik kept them busy.

Look closer and the street gets richer still. There were people working amber, that golden see-through stuff that is really tree sap turned hard as stone, carving it into beads and pendants. There were people cutting shiny black jet, a stone from the Yorkshire coast, into rings and lucky charms. There were metalworkers melting silver and bronze to make brooches, pins and coins, and leatherworkers stitching shoes, belts and knife covers. There were spinners and weavers turning sheep wool into cloth, then dyeing it bright colours using plants, red from the roots of a plant called madder, and yellows and blues from others, because Vikings loved colour and were not grey and gloomy at all.

Here is what is wonderful about all this. Kings and battles get remembered, but a whole city actually runs on ordinary skilled people making useful, beautiful things with their hands. Every comb someone lost, every broken cup, every scrap of leather and half-carved lump of amber tells us about a real worker who sat right here, one thousand years ago, concentrating hard, being good at their job.

So as you go round, look for the everyday objects, the combs and cups and beads and shoes. Each one had a maker. And thanks to the magic mud, we can still admire their work, long after their names were forgotten.

The Most Famous Poo in the World

You knew this was coming. JORVIK's most celebrated treasure — genuinely, scientifically celebrated — is a fossilized Viking poo. It's called the Lloyds Bank Coprolite, because it was found in 1972 under the site of a Lloyds Bank branch, and it is magnificent: about twenty centimeters long, the largest fossilized human dropping ever found. Scientists have studied it very seriously, and it's a gold mine of information. From it we know its maker ate mostly meat and bread, not many vegetables — and that they were infested with hundreds of parasitic worms, so their tummy ache was probably historic too. One scientist famously described the coprolite as being as precious, in its own way, as the Crown Jewels — a sentence he must regret at parties. In 2003, disaster struck: the coprolite was dropped during a school visit and broke into three pieces. It was carefully glued back together by experts, which is surely one of the strangest jobs in the history of museum conservation. Find it in its display case and pay your respects. Here's the real lesson hiding in the joke: kings write history books about themselves, but ordinary people leave behind rubbish, lost shoes, and yes, poo — and that's how we truly know how people lived. Science means studying everything. Everything.

What Was for Dinner in Jorvik?

You already know the famous poo tells us what one Viking ate. But scientists have studied seeds, bones, nutshells and rubbish pits from all over Jorvik, so we actually know a huge amount about Viking dinner. And some of it might surprise you.

First, the big rule. There were no potatoes, no tomatoes, no chocolate, no bananas, and no sugar as we know it. All of those come from faraway parts of the world that Europeans had not reached yet. A Viking child would never once have tasted a chip or a piece of chocolate. Imagine that.

So what did they eat? Lots of bread, dark and heavy, made from grain crushed between two big stones. Here is the not-so-tasty part. Little bits of grit from the grinding stones ended up in the flour, so every loaf was slightly gritty, and over a lifetime all that grit wore Viking teeth flat and smooth, like little pebbles. Scientists can often spot a Viking skull just from the worn-down teeth.

They ate meat when they could, beef, pork, mutton and chicken, plus eggs. They ate a lot of fish, both from the river and, more and more as the years went by, from the sea, herring and eel and more. They kept cows and goats for milk, and turned it into cheese and butter. From their gardens and the wild they got cabbages, leeks, onions, peas and beans, and they gathered apples, plums, cherries, blackberries and hazelnuts. For something sweet there was honey, the only sweet treat they had, and it was precious. To drink there was milk, water, and ale, a kind of weak beer, which even children sipped a little of, because it was cleaner than the dirty river water.

And nothing was wasted. Bones were boiled for soup and marrow, then sometimes carved into tools, pins, skates and toys. A Viking kitchen threw almost nothing away, which is lucky for us, because their leftovers and rubbish are exactly how we know all this.

So a Viking feast was hearty, brown and salty, full of bread and meat and fish and ale, sweetened only by honey and berries, and crunchy with just a little too much grit. Delicious, mostly. Hard on the teeth. And absolutely, definitely, no chocolate.

Your Ride Through a Thousand Years

In a few minutes you are going to climb into a little car and ride straight into the past. Before you do, here is what is really going on, because the JORVIK ride is much cleverer than it looks.

The carriages are called time cars, and they carry you slowly through a rebuilt Viking street. But this is not a made-up fairy-tale village. The people who built it used what the diggers found in the ground right here, so the houses stand exactly where real houses stood, the workshops make the things the real workshops made, and even the muddy paths follow the real streets. It is a full-size copy of Jorvik, built on the very spot where Jorvik once stood.

Look at the faces of some of the figures. A few of them were built from real Viking skulls found in York. Scientists can take a skull and, layer by layer, add on where the muscles and skin and nose and lips would have gone, until a real face from a thousand years ago stares back at you. So some of the people you glide past are not invented. They are portraits of actual Vikings who lived and died in this city.

Now, the part everyone talks about. The smells. As you ride, you will smell things, and they are there on purpose. Woodsmoke from the fires, fish from the market, leather from the workshops, and, yes, the pong of the toilet pit. The designers really did engineer Viking smells, because your nose remembers things your eyes forget, and they wanted you to feel how a crowded, busy, whiffy city actually felt. Try not to hold your breath. That is the whole point.

Listen too. The voices you hear are speaking Old Norse, the real language of Jorvik, worked out by scholars from old writings. You are hearing, more or less, what these streets actually sounded like.

One more thing to know. This whole ride was underwater not long ago. In December of two thousand fifteen, terrible floods poured into York and swamped the Viking street. The centre had to shut, and clever people spent a year and a half rebuilding it, better than before, adding everything scientists had learned since. Water once buried and saved the real Jorvik in the mud, and water later tried to destroy the copy, and people rebuilt it anyway.

So climb aboard, breathe in, and keep your eyes and ears and nose wide open. You are about to travel one thousand years, and every smelly, noisy, muddy detail is trying to tell you the truth.